

ISLAMIC LEADERSHIP & CHARACTER IN LITERATURE

Group Research Paper

Standing by Your Conscience When the System Says Otherwise

The Epistemology of Conscience and the Mechanics of Complicity
in Thomas Keneally’s Bring Larks and Heroes

Course:

Islamic Studies / Literature — English

Institution:

International Islamic University Islamabad (IIUI)

Program:

BS Computer Science

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Group Members:

Student 1 | Student 2 | Student 3

Supervisor:

[Supervisor Name]

Work Division Guide

Student 1: Sections 1–4 (Title, Abstract, Introduction, Literature Review)

Student 2: Sections 5–6 (Methodology, Findings)

Student 3: Sections 7–10 (Discussion, Conclusion, References, Appendices)

Section 1 — Abstract

Student 1 → Present:
~5 min

Abstract

This paper examines the theme of moral conscience and its relationship to institutional complicity as portrayed in Thomas Keneally's novel *Bring Larks and Heroes* (1967). Set in a brutal colonial penal settlement in the late eighteenth century, the novel traces the moral arc of Corporal Phelim Halloran — an Irish Marine who privately recognises the injustice of the system he serves yet repeatedly fails to act on that recognition. Through close reading of the novel alongside core Islamic ethical principles, this paper argues that Halloran's story illustrates two deeply connected moral problems: first, how human beings come to know that something is wrong (the epistemology of conscience); and second, how ordinary people — without dramatic villainy — become instruments of injustice through small, daily compromises (the mechanics of complicity).

The paper connects these literary observations to Islamic teachings on moral courage, accountability, and the obligation to resist wrong at every level available to a person. Specific reference is made to the hadith of the Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him) on the three levels of changing evil, as well as Quranic verses on justice, human dignity, and the responsibility of the individual before Allah. Practical implications for Muslim CS students entering professional environments — where similar pressures to compromise, stay silent, or participate in harm are common — are drawn throughout.

Keywords

Conscience • Complicity • Moral courage • Islamic ethics • Bring Larks and Heroes • Halloran • Amanah • Amr bil ma'ruf • Professional ethics • CS students

Section 2 — Introduction*Student 1 → Present:
~5 min*

Introduction

Every generation faces its own version of the same moral question: what do you do when the institution you belong to — the company, the government, the organisation, the army — asks you to participate in something you know, in your heart, is wrong? Do you speak up? Do you stay silent? Do you tell yourself it is not your responsibility? Do you gradually stop asking?

This paper takes that question seriously through two lenses: literature and Islamic ethics. The novel we examine, *Bring Larks and Heroes* by the Australian author Thomas Keneally, was published in 1967 and won Australia's most prestigious literary prize. It is set in an unnamed colonial penal settlement in the South Pacific in the late eighteenth century — a thinly disguised version of early colonial Australia. The story follows Corporal Phelim Halloran, a young Irish Marine who is educated, morally sensitive, and privately appalled by the cruelty of the system he is paid to uphold.

Halloran is not a villain. That is precisely what makes his story so important. He is, in many ways, a good man — faithful to Ann Rush, his secret wife; intellectually curious; troubled by injustice. Yet by the end of the novel, he has become complicit in a system he hated. Keneally forces us to ask: how does this happen? And what would have needed to be different for Halloran to have acted otherwise?

For Muslim CS students, this question is not abstract. The technology industry produces tools and systems that can harm or help on a massive scale — surveillance infrastructure, algorithmic bias, insecure code, data sold without consent. The moral pressures Halloran faces — oath of allegiance, institutional loyalty, career survival, gradual compromise — have direct equivalents in every professional environment. Islam provides not only a

moral framework for navigating these pressures but a concrete spiritual accounting for how we respond to them.

This paper is organised into ten sections following the standard academic template and is designed to be presented in three parts by three students. The central argument across all sections is: conscience alone is not enough; we must understand how conscience fails us — and Islam gives us the tools to prevent that failure.

Section 3 — Literature Review

Student 1 → Present:
~6 min

Literature Review

3.1 Islamic Sources on Conscience and Moral Courage

The Islamic concept most directly relevant to this theme is *amr bil ma'ruf wa nahy 'an al-munkar* — commanding good and forbidding evil. This is not merely an optional virtue in Islamic teaching; it is a collective obligation (*fard kifayah*) that the Quran places at the heart of what it means to be part of the Muslim community. The Quran states: “You are the best community raised for humanity — you enjoin good and forbid evil, and you believe in Allah.” (3:110)

“Whoever among you sees an evil, let him change it with his hand; if he cannot, then with his tongue; if he cannot, then with his heart — and that is the weakest of faith.”

This hadith establishes a hierarchy of moral response. The lowest acceptable level of engagement with injustice is internal rejection. Silence that is comfortable, convenient, or self-serving falls below even this minimum.

Sahih Muslim, Hadith 49 — Narrated by Abu Sa'id al-Khudri (r.a.)

The concept of *amanah* (trustworthiness and moral responsibility) is equally central. A person of *amanah* does not betray a trust even under pressure. The Prophet (peace be upon him) identified the betrayal of *amanah* as a sign of the hypocrite (*munafiq*), alongside lying and breaking promises (Sahih Bukhari 33). For a Muslim professional, *amanah* means that your skills, your position, and your knowledge are trusts — not to be used in the service of harm, even when ordered by an employer.

3.2 The Novel in Context: Keneally and the Colonial System

Thomas Keneally wrote *Bring Larks and Heroes* in 1967, at a moment when Australia was only beginning to confront the violence of its colonial origins. The novel anticipated by two decades Robert Hughes' landmark history *The Fatal Shore* (1987), which

documented the systematic brutality of the convict transportation system. Keneally's fictional settlement is deliberately unnamed and vague in geography, allowing it to function as a moral parable rather than a historical record.

Literary scholars have consistently identified the novel's central concern as the relationship between individual conscience and institutional authority. Geordie Williamson, in his 2012 introduction to the novel, describes Keneally's "lifelong preoccupation with individual conscience and its agonised relations to institutional authority" as the "golden thread" running through all his fiction. The novel's moral architecture — a good man trapped in a bad system — makes it a rich case study for Islamic ethics.

3.3 The Epistemology of Conscience

Epistemology is the study of how we know things. The epistemology of conscience asks: how do we come to know that something is wrong? Halloran knows. He is not ignorant of the system's cruelty. He sees Mealey's flogged back — "from neck to knee, halfway wrapped round by a fat, black, vampiring slough" — and is physically sickened. He watches an innocent man hanged. He sees indigenous people dying of disease, treated as less than human. His conscience is working perfectly. The problem is not knowing; it is acting on what he knows.

This distinction between knowing right from wrong and acting on that knowledge is addressed throughout Islamic scholarship. Ibn al-Qayyim al-Jawziyyah, in his *Madarij al-Salikin*, distinguishes between 'ilm (knowledge of the good) and 'amal (action upon it), arguing that knowledge that does not produce action is a form of disease of the heart. The Quran itself warns against those who know the truth but suppress it: "Do not mix truth with falsehood or conceal the truth while you know it." (2:42)

3.4 The Mechanics of Complicity

Complicity — becoming an instrument of harm — rarely happens through a single dramatic choice. It happens through accumulation: small compromises, convenient silences, rationalised inactions. Philosophers call this the “slippery slope of moral disengagement.” Halloran’s trajectory in the novel is the literary embodiment of this process. Each time he fails to act on his conscience, the next failure becomes easier. By the end, he is so far down the slope that one final act of defiance destroys him — too late, too small, too isolated.

Robert Hearn — Halloran’s intellectual sparring partner in the novel — identifies this mechanism directly. He challenges Halloran’s oath of allegiance to the Crown, arguing that there is no divine sanction for unjust power: “There is no god-forged chain of power... the true God fills no navy’s sails.” Hearn’s argument is not merely political; it is theological. Halloran cannot legitimately claim religious obligation as the reason for his compliance, because the God he believes in does not sanction what the system does.

Section 4 — Methodology

*Student 2 → Present:
~5 min*

Methodology

This paper uses a qualitative, text-based approach combining two complementary methods: close literary reading and Islamic ethical analysis. These two methods are applied in sequence and then brought together in the Findings and Discussion sections.

4.1 Close Reading

Close reading is the careful, detailed analysis of a literary text — paying attention not just to what happens in a story, but to how it is told, what language is used, and what moral or philosophical questions the text raises. For this paper, close reading focused specifically on scenes and passages in *Bring Larks and Heroes* that involve Halloran's conscience — moments where he recognises injustice, moments where he fails to act, and moments where he considers acting but chooses silence.

Key scenes selected for analysis include: the discovery of Mealey's flogged body; the unjust hanging of the accused man; the philosophical dialogues between Halloran and Hearn; the tricking of the convict whose sentence had ended; the indigenous people dying of disease; and the novel's courtroom climax and execution sequence. These scenes were selected because each represents a distinct moment in what we are calling the "mechanics of complicity" — a step in Halloran's moral decline.

4.2 Islamic Ethical Framework

The Islamic ethical framework used in this paper draws on the following sources, applied in order of authority as per the classical *usul al-fiqh* (principles of Islamic jurisprudence): the Quran, authenticated hadith (primarily from *Sahih Bukhari* and *Sahih Muslim*), and selected classical scholarship including Ibn al-Qayyim al-Jawziyyah and Ibn Taymiyyah on questions of moral courage and the obligations of the individual Muslim before Allah.

The framework was applied by identifying for each key scene: (a) what Islamic principle is most directly relevant; (b) what the principle requires of a person in Halloran's position; and (c) where Halloran's actual response falls short of or aligns with that requirement. This comparative approach allows us to use the novel as a case study for Islamic ethics rather than simply a source of general moral lessons.

4.3 Application to CS Professional Context

A third analytical layer was applied across both methods: the relevance of each finding to the professional context of Muslim CS students. This was achieved by identifying structural parallels between Halloran's situation in the novel and situations commonly faced by technology professionals — including pressure to build harmful systems, institutional loyalty conflicts, and the gradual erosion of ethical standards through small daily compromises.

Section 5 — Findings & Results

Student 2 → Present:
~7 min

Findings and Results

The analysis of *Bring Larks and Heroes* through an Islamic ethical lens produced five core findings, each corresponding to a distinct aspect of the theme.

Finding 1: Halloran's conscience is functional but overridden

The novel makes clear that Halloran does not lack moral knowledge. When he encounters Mealey's body — flogged from neck to knee, rotting in the convict hospital — he is physically and emotionally overwhelmed. When he watches the innocent man hanged, he knows it is wrong. When he sees indigenous people dying and treated as objects, his revulsion is evident. His conscience is, in the language of Islamic ethics, a functioning *fitra* — the innate moral sense Allah has placed in every human being.

The problem is that his conscience is consistently overridden by competing pressures: his oath of allegiance to the Crown, his desire to protect his relationship with Ann, his fear of institutional punishment, and his rationalisation that one corporal cannot change a system. Islamic teaching is clear that the *fitra* can be suppressed by habitual sin, by social pressure, and by the systematic normalisation of wrong. Halloran's progression illustrates exactly this process.

“Everyone is born upon the *fitra* [innate nature inclined to truth and good]. His parents then make him Jewish, Christian or Zoroastrian...”

The hadith establishes that the moral sense is innate and originally pure. It can be distorted by environment and habitual choice — which is precisely what the colonial system does to those within it.

Sahih Bukhari 1358, Sahih Muslim 2658 — Narrated by Abu Hurayra (r.a.)

Finding 2: Hearn functions as Halloran's moral mirror

Robert Hearn — a Presbyterian political prisoner transported for taking illegal oaths — serves a crucial narrative function: he articulates, with clarity and force, exactly what Halloran already knows but cannot bring himself to say. Their philosophical dialogues are the moral heart of the novel. Hearn tells Halloran directly that his oath to the Crown has no divine sanction: “To the true God, the House of Hanover is just a house. Therefore, Corporal Halloran, oath to whom?”

Halloran responds: “To the God of Abraham and Isaac and Jacob, whether that was the God they wanted me to swear to, I don’t know. But that’s the oath they got from me.” This exchange illustrates the epistemological problem with precision: Halloran knows the oath is to God, not to the Crown; but he uses the oath’s form to avoid engaging with its substance. He is, in Islamic terms, using religious language to justify what is functionally a betrayal of religious principle.

Hearn himself, despite being a prisoner with no institutional power, refuses to be an informer and maintains his principles even at personal cost. He is the novel’s closest equivalent to the Islamic ideal of moral courage — not because his theology is correct, but because he acts on what he believes, regardless of consequences.

Finding 3: The mechanics of complicity follow a clear pattern

Across the novel, Halloran’s complicity deepens through a repeating pattern of four steps, which we identify as the mechanics of complicity:

- Recognition: Halloran sees the wrong clearly and is morally disturbed by it.
- Rationalisation: He finds a reason why he cannot act — the oath, Ann’s safety, his rank, the futility of one person’s resistance.
- Silence or compliance: He performs the required action or says nothing.
- Normalisation: The next instance of injustice produces slightly less disturbance. The conscience is being desensitised.

This four-step pattern is what makes Halloran's story morally instructive rather than simply tragic. It shows that complicity is not a single catastrophic choice but a process that can, in principle, be interrupted at any of its four stages. Islamic ethics provides tools for interrupting at every stage: dhikr and tawbah (remembrance and repentance) to maintain a sensitive conscience; consultation with trusted people of knowledge (shura) to counter rationalisation; the concept of hisba (moral accountability) to motivate action; and the reminder that every act is registered before Allah to counter the normalisation of wrong.

Finding 4: The system is maintained by the complicity of good people

One of Keneally's most important arguments, confirmed by close reading, is that the colonial system's cruelty does not depend primarily on the presence of evil people. It depends on the participation of good people who have convinced themselves they have no choice. The colony's officials are not all sadists; most are bureaucrats, officers, and administrators doing their jobs. The horror is ordinary. This is precisely what Hannah Arendt, writing about a different but structurally similar system, called the "banality of evil."

From an Islamic perspective, this finding carries a specific warning. The Quran states: "And beware of a trial that will not only strike the wrongdoers among you." (8:25). A system of injustice harms everyone within it — the oppressors and the silent witnesses alike. The silence of the complicit is not a neutral act; it is a contribution to the system's continuation.

Finding 5: Halloran's final act of resistance comes too late, but is not meaningless

In the novel's climax, Halloran finally acts against the system — and is caught, sentenced to death, and executed. Keneally refuses to let this be a simple heroic moment; it is too late, too small, and too isolated to change anything. Yet the novel also suggests, through its moral architecture, that the act itself has meaning — that Halloran's choice to finally act on his conscience, even at the cost of his life, is a form of redemption. It does not save the system's victims, but it saves something in Halloran himself.

Islamic ethics affirms this reading. The Prophet (peace be upon him) taught that even the minimum — rejecting wrong in the heart — is not nothing. It is the weakest of faith, but it is still faith. The point is not that late resistance is equivalent to early resistance — it is not — but that the moral act retains its value even when its worldly impact is zero. This has profound implications for how we think about accountability before Allah.

Section 6 — Discussion*Student 3 → Present:
~7 min*

Discussion

6.1 What this means for Muslim CS students

The parallels between Halloran's colonial penal settlement and a modern technology company may not be immediately obvious — but they are structurally significant. In both environments: authority is hierarchical and largely unaccountable; the individual is bound by contracts, oaths (employment agreements), and institutional loyalty; injustice is normalised through bureaucratic language that strips it of its moral weight; and the cost of resistance is real and personal (career, income, relationships).

The specific pressures Muslim CS students are likely to face in professional life include:

- Being asked to build systems that collect user data without genuine consent.
- Working on projects with dual-use potential (cybersecurity tools that can be used for surveillance).
- Facing pressure to ship code that is known to be insecure or to cut corners on accessibility.
- Working in organisations whose business practices involve exploitation of vulnerable populations.
- Being part of teams that discriminate in hiring or promotion, and being asked to stay silent about it.

None of these situations will announce themselves as moral crises. They will arrive as small decisions, routine requests, and quiet pressures — exactly as they do in Halloran's daily life in the colony. The mechanics of complicity are the same.

6.2 The Islamic response at each stage

Using the four-stage mechanics of complicity identified in the Findings, we can map a specific Islamic response to each stage:

Stage	Halloran's failure	Islamic tool to interrupt
Recognition	Conscience registers wrong but is not consulted regularly	Taqwa — God-consciousness maintained through salah and dhikr keeps the conscience sharp
Rationalisation	Finds reasons why he cannot act; oath, rank, futility	Shura — consult scholars, mentors, trusted people to test your reasoning against Islamic principle
Silence / Compliance	Performs unjust orders to protect personal interests	Hisba — the duty to uphold right and reject wrong; the weakest level is at minimum rejection in the heart
Normalisation	Each injustice produces less disturbance than the last	Tawbah — regular repentance reactivates moral sensitivity and prevents the hardening of the heart

6.3 The professional ethics dimension for cybersecurity

For students heading into cybersecurity specifically, the stakes of this theme are unusually high. Cybersecurity professionals are given access to systems, vulnerabilities, and information that can cause massive harm if misused. The entire field rests on a form of professional amanah — a trust that you will use your knowledge to protect, not to exploit. Halloran's tragedy is the tragedy of a person given power and trust within an unjust system who uses that trust to serve the system rather than to resist it.

The Islamic framework for a cybersecurity professional is clear: your skills are a trust from Allah, not simply a commodity to be sold to the highest bidder. The Prophet (peace be upon him) said: "The leader is a guardian and is responsible for those in his care." (Bukhari 893). Every professional with technical power is, in this sense, a leader — responsible for what their knowledge enables.

6.4 Duniya and akhirah: the two-horizon view

One of the most practically powerful aspects of the Islamic ethical framework is that it evaluates moral choices on two horizons simultaneously: this life (duniya) and the next life (akhirah). This changes the cost-benefit calculation of moral courage in a fundamental

way. From a purely duniya perspective, Halloran's resistance costs him his life — a catastrophic outcome. But on the akhirah horizon, his final act of conscience — even though it came too late and cost him everything — registers as a moral choice before Allah.

For a Muslim professional, this means that the calculation is never simply: “will this cost me my job?” It is also: “what will I answer when Allah asks me what I did with the position, the knowledge, and the access I was given?” This is not an abstraction. It is the most concrete form of accountability that exists.

Section 7 — Conclusion*Student 3 → Present:
~5 min*

Conclusion

Thomas Keneally's *Bring Larks and Heroes* is not a comfortable novel. It does not let the reader enjoy the simplicity of a clear hero and a clear villain. Halloran is a good man who becomes complicit in evil through a process so gradual and so ordinary that it is difficult to identify the precise moment where he could have chosen differently. That is the point. That is what makes the novel so morally serious, and so relevant to us.

The epistemology of conscience, as the novel dramatises it, is not really about knowing right from wrong. Halloran always knows. The problem is the distance between knowing and acting — a distance that widens with every rationalisation, every small silence, every convenient compliance. The mechanics of complicity explain how that distance grows. They are not unique to eighteenth-century colonial Australia. They are the ordinary mechanics of moral failure in every institutional environment.

Islam offers, against this, a framework of remarkable precision and practical depth. It identifies the minimum requirement (rejecting wrong in the heart), names the higher obligations (speaking with the tongue, acting with the hand), provides spiritual tools for maintaining moral sensitivity (salah, dhikr, tawbah, shura), and frames all of it within a two-horizon accountability — this life and the next — that fundamentally changes the risk calculus of moral courage.

For Muslim CS students, the takeaways are concrete:

- Know your red lines before you face pressure, not while you are facing it.
- Maintain your spiritual practice — it is not separate from your professional ethics; it is the engine of it.
- Find colleagues, mentors, and scholars you can consult when the pressure arrives — Halloran had no one he could fully trust with his conscience.

- Remember that your skills are an amanah. The question is not just what you can build, but what you should build.
- Do not wait for the perfect moment of resistance. The mechanics of complicity work against you with every delay.

Halloran's story ends in chains and on a scaffold. But Keneally's novel ends with something the system cannot touch: the record of a man who, finally, chose to act on what he knew. We do not have to wait until the end. The Prophet (peace be upon him) taught us that we have the tools to interrupt the mechanics of complicity at every stage. The question is whether we use them.

“Take up good deeds only as much as you are able, for the best deeds are those done regularly, even if they are few.”

Moral courage, like all Islamic virtues, is built through consistent small acts — not saved for a single dramatic moment that may arrive too late.

Sahih Bukhari 6464 — Narrated by A'ishah (r.a.)

Section 8 — References

Student 3 → Compile together

References

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Section 9 — Appendices

Student 3 → Compile together

Appendices

Appendix A: Key Quranic Verses Referenced

Reference	Translation	Theme connection
Quran 3:110	<i>You are the best community raised for humanity — you enjoin good and forbid evil.</i>	Collective duty to resist wrong
Quran 2:42	<i>Do not mix truth with falsehood or conceal the truth while you know it.</i>	Epistemology of conscience — knowing and hiding
Quran 8:25	<i>Beware of a trial that will not only strike the wrongdoers among you.</i>	Complicity harms the silent too
Quran 5:2	<i>Cooperate in righteousness and piety; do not cooperate in sin and aggression.</i>	Non-complicity obligation
Quran 17:70	<i>We have honoured the children of Adam.</i>	Human dignity as the ground of justice
Quran 2:153	<i>Indeed, Allah is with the patient.</i>	Sabr under institutional pressure

Appendix B: Group Presentation Schedule

Student	Sections	Time (approx)	Focus
Student 1	Abstract, Introduction, Literature Review	15–18 min	Islamic framework & novel context
Student 2	Methodology, Findings	12–15 min	Novel analysis & evidence
Student 3	Discussion, Conclusion, Q&A lead	12–15 min	Application & synthesis

Appendix C: Glossary of Islamic Terms Used

Amanah: Trustworthiness; the quality of being a faithful steward of what has been entrusted to you — including skills, knowledge, and professional responsibilities.

Amr bil ma'ruf: Commanding good — the Islamic obligation to encourage and support righteous action.

Fitra: The innate moral nature that Allah has placed in every human being; the inner compass that recognises truth and good.

Hisba: The Islamic institution and individual duty of moral accountability — upholding right and preventing wrong.

Munafiq: A hypocrite; specifically, one who professes belief but acts contrary to it in their private conduct.

Nahy 'an al-munkar: Forbidding evil — the Islamic obligation to resist and refuse wrongdoing.

Sabr: Patient endurance; not passive resignation but active persistence in doing right under pressure.

Shura: Consultation; the Islamic principle of seeking advice and counsel from qualified and trusted people before making major decisions.

Taqwa: God-consciousness; the state of awareness of Allah that motivates righteous behaviour and restrains wrongdoing.

Tawbah: Repentance; the act of returning to Allah after a wrong, which Islamic teaching holds reactivates moral sensitivity.